

EPILOGUE

You live in a deranged age – more deranged than usual – because despite great scientific and technological advances, man has not the faintest idea of who he is or what he is doing.

—Walker Percy^[^1]

The great departs; the small approaches. Thus heaven and earth do not unite, and all beings fail to achieve union. Upper and lower do not unite, and in the world, states go down to ruin.

—I Ching^[^2]

Strength lies in improvisation. All the decisive blows are struck left-handed.

—Walter Benjamin^[^3]

I often feel sympathy for novelists and crime-writers, who must be aware that there is a type of reader who will leap straight to the final chapter to discover whodunnit even before anything has been dunn. It destroys, of course, one of the pleasures of reading the book. Authors of books such as this one are not immune from the same problem, and in our case it is even worse. Readers who turn first to the final chapter often do so as a substitute for reading the book as a whole, and inevitably come away with a much cruder idea of what the book suggests. Final chapters, epilogues, and other ‘last words’ can contain none of the subtleties, complexities or indeed the caveats, of the book itself. Yet some sort of concluding chapter is almost always necessary.

However, I have to disappoint the casual browser. Let me state clearly that what follows is in no sense even an approximate ‘summary’ of the book’s argument. It isn’t a summary at all. I feel my loyalty is to those readers who have accompanied me from the beginning and have arrived at this point in the conventional manner. I therefore see paying my debt to them as my showing how what, at times, might have seemed somewhat remote from the concerns that press on us – discussions of the nature of time, space and movement, for example – nonetheless bear directly upon our experience in the world today. In the book I have put forward for the reader’s consideration a form of cosmology – and, in the simplest sense, a philosophy of life: all of that was best expressed where I took time to do so, and to express it less carefully now would be both superfluous and counterproductive.

This epilogue, then, presents not a backward glance at where we have been, but a projection forward into the plight of our contemporary world, and how that philosophy may be of relevance here. Those who read only what follows rather than the book as a whole may be tempted to see here the conventional ‘conclusions’ which a final chapter might provide. If so, they might well protest that the ‘conclusions’ are nothing new. In one sense they are right – there is nothing new under the sun. All I hope to do in these last pages is hint at how our exploration of the brain and its contributions to mind can help us see things we might not otherwise see, and which indeed we are no longer permitting ourselves to see; see new

connexions between otherwise disparate phenomena; and see what we do see in a different light. Whether I have succeeded or not, however, can be judged, I would suggest, only by those who do, in fact, read the book.

It is often said that we are experiencing a crisis of meaning. Not coincidentally, far more of us than ever before in the history of the world live divorced from Nature, alienated from the structures and traditions of a stable society, and indifferent to the divine. These three elements have always been what have provided us with an overarching sense of belonging: our relations with the living world, with one another, and with a divine realm. (They also turn out from contemporary research, unsurprisingly, to be the three elements that most determine one's happiness and fulfilment as a human being.)^[4] Alas, they are no longer open to us: we have seen to that. We exist in the world, of course, but we no longer belong in this world – or any world worthy of the name. We have unmade the world. This is entirely new in the history of humanity and it is impossible to exaggerate its significance.

Each of these divorces has come about very swiftly – in a mere 250–300 years – the twinkling of an eye in relation to the age of humanity. And they have each come about because of an access of hubris. Nature has become mere resource; the divine mere superstition; and the unruly complexity of life can, we believe, be simply rationalised, ironed out, and subjected to our conscious control, by technology, by bureaucracy and, where necessary, by law. We know far more, we think, than people of other ages and cultures; indeed we pretty much know it all. However, I suggest, no people that ever lived has understood so little.

In the ninth-century Chinese classic, *The Secret of the Golden Flower*, it is written that 'the conscious mind is like a violent general of a strong fiefdom controlling things from a distance, until the sword is turned around.'^[5] The sinologist Thomas Cleary comments: 'Zen Buddhism traditionally describes the mechanism of delusion as mistaking the servant for the master. In the metaphor of this passage, the general is supposed to be a servant but instead usurps authority.'^[6] In both the Zen and Taoist traditions, the narrowly circumscribed conscious mind, according to Cleary, 'is supposed to be a servant of the original mind' – original here meaning the ontologically prior and deeper-lying mind, on which the 'conscious mind' depends for understanding. When 'the sword is turned around ... the original mind retrieves command over the delinquent conscious mind'.^[7] In a subsequent passage Cleary adds, unknowingly, but precisely, describing the way in which the two hemispheres work best together (the interpolations in square brackets are of course mine):

Intuition belongs to the original spirit; intellect belongs to the conscious spirit. The essence of Taoism is to refine the conscious spirit [LH] to reunite it with the original spirit [RH] ...

self-delusion occurs when the servant has taken over from the master; self-enlightenment takes place when the master is restored to autonomy in the centre.

As he points out, this is an image of 'an ideal relationship between the original spirit as the source of power and the conscious spirit as a subordinate functionary':

In this way the intellect [LH] functions efficiently in the world without that conscious activity inhibiting access to deeper spontaneous knowledge through the direct intuition of a more subtle faculty [RH].^[8]

Why is the sword said to be turned around? Because the highest achievement of the analytic intellect – and this only very rarely happens – comes when it knows when to stop: how to turn its power, where necessary, on itself, so as to see its proper limits and to abide by them. To quote Heidegger once more, 'The evil and thus keenest danger is thinking itself. It must think against itself, which it can only seldom do.'⁹ I dare to hope that this book may aid in one of those rare instances of the intellect's becoming aware of its own limitations; coming once more to play the invaluable role of servant, rather than pretending to be the Master, without having any of the necessary insight into, or wisdom about, what it is doing.

In *The Master and his Emissary* I laid out, first, the neuropsychological grounds of the hemisphere hypothesis and its philosophical consequences; and, then, what I could see happened to a civilisation when its ethos, instead of encouraging the proper working together of the hemispheres, began to favour a very particular outlook, one that can readily be shown to conform to the mode of operation of the left hemisphere alone. I did this by reviewing the major turning points in the history of ideas in the West through the lens of that hypothesis, which to me provided a grave warning. I was, and am now still more, fearful that unless we radically change the path we are pursuing we cannot survive – certainly as a civilisation, and perhaps as a species. In the last chapter of that book I asked the reader to imagine what the world would look like if I were right that we had more or less confined ourselves to seeing it from the very narrow, highly skewed, standpoint of the left hemisphere. Few readers have needed much prompting to recognise in it the world where we live now.

Any reader of this book will, by now, be very familiar with the consequences of the view made possible by the left hemisphere. So I will not need to spend much time on them: the most obvious of these can be listed fairly succinctly. In each case we achieve the opposite of what we intend.

OUR LEFT HEMISPHERE WORLD: 'ARROGANT DRAGON WILL HAVE CAUSE TO REPENT'

We have lost the sense of the broad picture, and the feeling for the whole, resulting in despoliation of the planet, exploitation of poorer nations, and extinction of the way of life of indigenous peoples. We have for some time now disregarded, and latterly traduced, the ancient wisdom of our cultures, and simultaneously acted with contempt for future generations. Social cohesion is breaking down in the face of atomistic individualism; and we are experiencing an epidemic of depression, anxiety and loneliness. Context is absolutely essential to the understanding of every utterance and every deed; yet we neglect the importance of context, so that words and deeds are ripped from their anchors in life and subject to comprehensive misunderstanding – all of which is exacerbated by the Procrustean effect of soundbite culture, and by the fragmentation of our attention. We sit in judgment on other times and other places, the art, literature and history of the past, and other people's cultures; yet we have no idea how very weird our own values are when set in context. We

neglect all that is implicit, which is nine-tenths of what matters, and which can't be made explicit without destroying its meaning and value: this is even affecting our ability to understand tone of voice and to read faces. The 'what' has come to triumph over the 'how', the goal over the means, the brute 'this must be done' over the manner in which it is done. There is a growth of machine-like inflexibility, loss of judgment and discretion, and a culture of petty rules that strangle initiative and affront our humanity. We are witnessing the triumph of black and white judgments, especially in the 'culture wars', where there is no vestige of subtlety in our thinking,^[10] no patience for the complex, and often little or no empathy, but rather anger and self-righteousness. We are newly beset by a tyranny of literal-mindedness – affecting our capacity to understand metaphors, humour, and irony, which increasingly are being driven out of public converse and out of our lives. We have replaced the living and unique by simple categories everywhere: a tick-box mentality. We have substituted quantity for quality – and 'productivity' for creativity (another aspect of the 'what' killing off the 'how'). We have an insatiable need for control – approaching total control, not just of action, but now of thought, through surveillance by both state and global capitalism. We are engaged in a war on the body, since it resists our free fantasies of limitless possibility, even if only by ensuring that one day we die; simultaneously we deny the existence of the soul, which is not something that exists over against embodiment, but is enmeshed with it. We kid ourselves that frenetic activity is a sign of life, not the desperation of people who have no idea what they are doing or why they are doing it, locked into a competition they cannot see how to escape; and which is destroying the world. And all this is accompanied by a blind optimism, born of the denial of consequences.

Every aspect of this reflects, as the reader will recognise, a prepotency of the left hemisphere's modus operandi. In Parts I and II, we saw how this leads, literally, to delusion; and in Part III, by revisioning the world, I drew attention to how we are unmaking it. We are out of touch with reality, to which the right hemisphere's world-picture would still give us access, if only we didn't dismiss it. In our world, the real, possibly cataclysmic, threats we are facing are in effect denied, while in their place new, hitherto unimagined, 'threats' to our sensitive natures are invented, which then proceed to take up a disproportionate part of our attention. It puts me in mind of a patient I looked after who, following a right hemisphere stroke, was not the least bit concerned that the whole left side of her body was paralysed – indeed, like many right hemisphere-damaged patients, she denied that it was so; but she was absolutely convinced that she was being victimised by a patient in the next bed, who had, she thought, contrived to steal her magazines and subtly poison her food.

One of the themes of this book has been that when we don't truly understand what we are doing and why we are doing it, life appears 'paradoxical': we set out to achieve one end and reach its exact opposite. Indeed, because of our unusual world view, we are constantly in a state of surprise about the way our plans don't work out. (When I say 'we', I acknowledge that many of my readers will object that they are no part of this; that is good, but you must then accept that you are the dissidents on whom nothing less than our future depends.) As a society, we pursue happiness and become measurably less happy over time. We privilege

autonomy, and end up bound by rules to which we never assented, and more spied on than any people since the beginning of time. We pursue leisure through technology, and discover that the average working day is longer than ever, and that we have less time than we had before. The means to our ends are ever more available, while we have less sense of what our ends should be, or whether there is purpose in anything at all. Economists carefully model and monitor the financial markets in order to avoid any future crash: they promptly crash. We are so eager that all scientific research result in 'positive findings' that it has become progressively less adventurous and more predictable, and therefore discovers less and less that is a truly significant advance in scientific thinking. We grossly misconceive the nature of study in the humanities as utilitarian, in order to get value for money, and thus render it pointless and, in this form, certainly a waste of resource. We 'improve' education by dictating curricula and focussing on exam results to the point where free-thinking, arguably an overarching goal of true education, is discouraged; in our universities many students are, in any case, so frightened that the truth might turn out not to conform to their theoretical model that they demand to be protected from discussions that threaten to examine the model critically; and their teachers, who should know better, in a serious dereliction of duty, collude. We over-sanitise and cause vulnerability to infection; we over-use antibiotics, leading to super-bacteria that no antibiotic can kill; we make drugs illegal to protect society, and, while failing comprehensively to control the use of drugs, create a fertile field for crime; we protect children in such a way that they cannot cope with – let alone relish – uncertainty or risk, and are rendered vulnerable.

The left hemisphere's motivation is control; and its means of achieving it alarmingly linear, as though it could see only one of the arrows in a vastly complex network of interactions at any one time. Which is all it can. If these paradoxes surprise us it is because we have not thought far enough ahead in time or broadly enough in space: we take a small part of the complex for the whole. The awareness coming from the right hemisphere can embrace that of the left, but not the other way round. When the hemispheres are working together under the unifying influence of the right hemisphere, the effect is not purely additive, but transformative. However, since the left hemisphere not only 'takes in' less, but understands what it takes in less well, our almost exclusive reliance on it, the servant, in contemporary Western culture, is a problem of some considerable proportions. Indeed, like civilisations before us, which drifted further and further to the outlook of the left hemisphere, we would appear to be engaged in committing suicide, intellectual and moral – if not indeed literal; excluding whole aspects of reality, resulting in a version of the world that 'computes' as far as the left hemisphere is concerned, but is grossly impoverished and lacking in meaning. One that is, in sum, more fit for a computer than a human being.

The focus of our thought is constrained because we think in terms of linear systems, when linear thinking is inadequate to the task. The result is what David Bohm called 'sustained incoherence', and its manifestations are all around us. He linked it to what he calls 'thought', which is clearly a description of left hemisphere thinking, even down to the denial: There is another major feature of thought: thought doesn't know it is doing something and

then it struggles against what it is doing. It doesn't want to know that it is doing it. And it struggles against the results, trying to avoid those unpleasant results while keeping on with that way of thinking. That is what I call sustained incoherence.[^11]

Later he has this to say: 'If there is sustained incoherence, it just keeps on going in spite of the fact that there is evidence which would show that it's incoherent. Now, we could say that an intelligent response on seeing incoherence would be to stop it, to suspend it and begin to look out for the reason for the incoherence and then to change it. But I say there is a defensive incoherence'.[^12] In other words the left hemisphere, above all else, doesn't want to hear why it might have got things wrong, as we have seen in this book time and time again. I see widespread evidence of this strange mentality in corporations, governments, health systems and education – everywhere that management 'culture' holds sway – that when things go wrong it is never that we have been travelling in the wrong direction, or have gone too far in what may once have been the right direction, only that we have not gone far enough. This links to the Dunning-Kruger effect: the less you know, the smarter you think you are. A further finding by Dunning and colleagues, however, helps make clear the relationship with the left hemisphere mindset, not only because of its relatively blinkered vision, but because of its preference for simple linear algorithms and procedures that 'logically must' lead to a certain outcome. Those who have such procedures think they must be in the right, even when the outcome ought to compel them to the opposite conclusion. Once they are committed to their theory of how things work, drawing attention to its glaringly obvious failure in the real world leads not to a flicker of doubt, but to a rise in confidence and redoubled efforts along the same line.[^13]

Once more the I Ching offers insight:

The person who ... keeps on striving when the maximum of influence has already been achieved, knowing only how to press forward and not how to retreat, isolates himself from the human sphere and loses his success. For what is complete cannot endure, and what is pushed to the limit ends in misfortune. Thus the last line says, 'Arrogant dragon will have cause to repent'.[^14]

Although our current public discourse often implies the opposite, nothing is ever simply yes or no, but always a matter of degree: 'yes, but'. Or, in another Zen saying I love: 'not always so'. Carved into the stone of the ancient temple of Apollo at Delphi, along with the injunction to 'know thyself', was the epitome of wisdom: *mēden agan*, 'nothing in excess'. (I didn't fully understand that in my teens; I do now.) Any principle that is extended too far, without respect to the opposite that is always inherent in it, may turn into the very thing that is being avoided and denied: its dark side. This is especially the case if there is no civilised dialogue between opposing camps. One extreme will simply flip into the other. Moreover, bureaucracy is an unwitting accomplice in generating extremism. The answer to every ill now is to appoint, often at public expense, an officer, and an office, whose job is to see only one side of a question. Once appointed, these 'tsars' and their tsardoms will not do themselves out of a job by saying, at any point whatever, there is little to be done, since a balance has now been achieved. They

will press on regardless, and without any obvious end in sight, finding ever more minute infractions of their principles to deal with by means of further regulation: a hugely wasteful and destructive process, leading to the incubation of resentment. And nobody dares wind them up, for fear of giving the 'wrong message'.

Disregard for the future is matched by disregard for the past and its hard-won wisdoms. 'No self is of itself alone', wrote Schrödinger: 'The "I" is chained to ancestry by many factors ... This is not mere allegory, but an eternal memory.'^[15] Because we are part of a living whole in time and space, we have responsibilities to our ancestors, to one another now, and to future generations, something that what we call 'simple' peoples and 'simple' cultures have always known and taken into account. Ironically, with globalisation, the world has become contracted in space and time to the infinitely thin slice which represents just 'me', here and now. A society is not derived from an assemblage of individuals, but individuals derive from the organism that is a society. 'The individual actually grows', wrote the social philosopher Norbert Elias, 'from a network of people existing before him into a network that he helps to form: the individual person is not a beginning and his relations to other people have no beginnings.' And he compares it to a conversation where 'the questions of one evoke the answers of the other and vice versa', something that 'can be understood – like the figure of a thread in a net – only from the totality of the network'.^[16] For this reason, as Viktor Frankl observed, 'individuality can only be valuable when it is not individuality for its own sake, but individuality for the human community.'^[17] Social understanding, empathy, connectedness, being concerned more with duties than rights, seeing the need for self-discipline, not self-indulgence – all this the reader will know is also far better understood by the right hemisphere than the left.

Is it not the case, though, it may be objected, that technology, the left hemisphere's extension of its power, is helping to bring one world together? 'Poisonous nonsense.' That was the answer given by Waldo Frank, an American historian of mixed race, in an essay called 'The central problem of modern Man', published in 1946. Pointing to air travel, television and radio as the media of such supposed 'one-worlding', he noted, with remarkable foresight, that with them come voices, visions, wills, that are products of, and spokesmen for, disintegration; come special and sectional pulls; come egoisms both individual and collective ... the crowded, noisy ignorance of the modern world is less easily invaded by knowledge than was the silence of illiterate epochs. But the peril is more positive ... Each faction of the unassembled body of integration, each with a part of truth but standing alone, asserting itself alone, multiplies disintegration; causes a pendulum swing from one partial extreme to another. One wonders what he would say if alive today. But to me what makes his comment so astute is the comparison he makes. Unlike a single cell, or an organism (as the reader of Chapter 12 will remember vividly), to which a society is often compared, we lack any distinct sense of an overall form, or Gestalt. So he continues:

... the reason is, of course, the want of pre-existent balance, the organism's way of digesting all it absorbs, using and rejecting according to its form. We thus find ourselves in a vicious circle: because we lack the organic sense to begin with, we misuse or deform the trends in our world that should move us toward it.^[18]

Those who have accompanied me on the trip so far will recognise in North American native myths, ancient Judaic wisdom and Chinese philosophical literature analogies to the myth enshrined in the title of *The Master and his Emissary*. Versions of this insight into the over-reaching nature of mere left hemisphere 'intellect' exist, in fact, in many cultures. (I put the word intellect in inverted commas because, as the reader will know, intellect must not be confused with intelligence, which it often lacks.) The insight is present in Rumi;[^19] it is present in the Jewish legend of the Golem; and versions are also found in Sanskrit literature including the Mahabharata. All of these, including *The Secret of the Golden Flower*, were unknown to me when I wrote that book. Yet these ancient insights were exactly where neurological research has led me. Nor are these 'merely' ancient insights. Here is the neuropsychologist Stuart Dimond speaking: 'Language immediately makes a claim for itself to be a prince among the mental processes, and to be the exclusive medium of mental function, denying often by its existence the presence of other modes of thought.'[^20]

As David Bohm also saw, our conscious thought processes are not, as they proclaim themselves to be, neutral, but motivated by the values, such as they are, of the left hemisphere:

One of the obvious things wrong with thought is fragmentation. Thought is breaking things up into bits which should not be broken up ... and at the same time we are trying to establish unity where there isn't any [through categorisation] ... Thus we have false division and false unification. Thought is always doing a great deal, but it tends to say that it hasn't done anything, that it is just telling you the way things are ... that 'you' are inside there, deciding what to do with the information. But I want to say that you don't decide what to do with the information. The information takes over. It runs you. Thought runs you. Thought, however, gives the false information that you are running it, that you are the one who controls thought, whereas actually thought is the one which controls each one of us. Until thought is understood – better yet, more than understood, perceived – it will actually control us; but it will create the impression that it is our servant, that it is just doing what we want it to do.[^21] Making 'thought' perceivable to our thinking has been one major aim of this book. Bohm carries on to say that 'thought is creating divisions out of itself and then saying that they are there naturally ... thought divides itself from feeling and from the body.' Once again he unwittingly describes the left hemisphere, cut off from emotion, the body, and all other forms of knowledge; not seeing what it is it cannot see; power-hungry, and seductive as the serpent with its air of innocence offering fruit from the tree of 'knowledge'.[^22] But his astonishingly clear insight is that, as I too believe, we are in the grip of something bigger than us that tells us it has our interests at heart in order the better to control us. And it has been devastatingly successful.

As the theory of complex systems shows, within such a system, while every single part has its effect on the whole, no single part can determine, or necessarily influence, or even perceive, where the whole is nonetheless tending. In 1922, Rilke wrote in one of his *Sonnets to Orpheus*:
When the machine presumes to inhabit our minds,
rather than be at our command,

it threatens everything we have achieved.
That the lovelier hesitancy of the master's hand
may be no longer manifest, it cuts the stone
for its more resolute work to an unyielding line.
It tarries nowhere, so that we might escape from it,
just for once – and leave it be,
oiling away in some quiet factory.
It is life – it thinks it knows best,
as it orders and makes and destroys
with the same determination.[^23]

This sounds a lot like Bohm's 'thought' that thinks it knows best, pretends to serve, but is quietly in control: and indeed that 'the machine presumes to inhabit our minds, rather than be at our command' is a perfect description of the left hemisphere usurping the right. What Rilke's poem as a whole makes clear is that 'the machine' is a drive, not just a thing: a drive that is implacably opposed to the human, and (as the rest of the poem declares) to all that is vulnerable, beautiful, subtle, holy or awe-inspiring. It destroys. And as before, in the very act of giving up our freedom, we imagine we are the ones that are in control.

Analysis has the capacity to take to pieces (literally, from Greek ἀναλύειν, to 'undo', 'break up' or 'dissolve') what already exists: but, like Flint in the Iroquois legend, it is impotent to bring things into being on its own. I earlier quoted Jan Zwicky on the analytic process: 'Carried too far too often, we lose the sense that something is amiss when the patient exhibits no life. We come to take pride in our cases of polished bone.' Life or vitality comes to us from the body and the unconscious, not from the exercise of analytic reason; much as the gardener does not make the plants, or make them grow, but merely trims and tends the natural vigour that comes from elsewhere – in this case out of the earth and the seed. D.H. Lawrence referred to 'the true unconscious, where our life bubbles up in us, prior to any mentality';[^24] and elsewhere, in speaking of his embodied existence, whether sick or well, 'I am alive, alive to the depths of my soul, and in touch somewhere with the vivid life of the cosmos'.[^25] It is hard to feel alive when you have done everything possible to deny the existence of your embodiment, as man or woman – which is flesh and blood, not merely dry bones, however well-polished. And then we will die, of course; but does that necessarily mean we were ever really alive? It seems to me that, in Kürnberger's phrase, life itself no longer lives. We are, more than anything else, devitalised: another predictable consequence of left hemisphere domination. Mechanism has triumphed over organism.

Because of our lack of sense of the cohesion of a dynamic whole, we end up acting in bad faith. Not for the first time, it is Erwin Chargaff who puts it most vividly:
Our time is cursed with the necessity for feeble men, masquerading as experts, to make enormously far-reaching decisions ... You can stop splitting the atom; you can stop visiting the moon; you can stop using aerosols; you may even decide not to kill entire populations by the use of a few bombs. But you cannot recall a new form of life ... The world is given to us on

loan. We come and we go; and after a time we leave earth and air and water to others who come after us. My generation, or perhaps the one preceding mine, has been the first to engage, under the leadership of the exact sciences, in a destructive colonial warfare against nature. The future will curse us for it.[^26]

In the second half of *The Master and his Emissary* I aimed to show how we have succumbed twice in the West (at the end of the Greek and Roman civilisations) and are now succumbing for the third time, to the temptation to see the world only through the eyes of the left hemisphere emissary. In the past this has coincided with the over-reaching of an empire, as today, and the collapse of a civilisation, as I fear awaits us tomorrow. But never has the hold of the left hemisphere on us been more complete than it is today. Its form of attention to the world and way of being in it confront us wherever we look. The sword must be turned around if we are to survive.

THE PURSUIT OF HAPPINESS

Let me ask one simple question. Has our weird inversion of values made us happier? We are the world's most relentless ever seekers after hedonic happiness: pursuing personal pleasure. This only succeeds in setting us on 'the hedonic treadmill', whose results are a restless, endless yearning for more of something we know not what, a craving that can never be fulfilled. Eudaimonic happiness, by contrast, is the result of leading a more 'other-centred', rather than self-centred life, of self-restraint – in short, living unostentatiously what has traditionally been called a virtuous life; it gives rise to a sense of fulfilment and vitality. By contrast with hedonic happiness, it protects against depression, and lowers all-cause mortality: it is also more dependent on the right hemisphere.[^27]

The pursuit of hedonic happiness depends upon a set of values that our society has taken to be axiomatically superior. These are the values of individualism: personal autonomy, control, choice. But the evidence is that they do not provide a pathway to a happy life – rather the reverse. In fact at the heart of all this is what has come to be known as the 'vulnerability paradox'. Cultures can be characterised by four main measures, according to the most widely adopted criteria in cross-cultural psychology, those of Geert Hofstede: greater or lesser inequalities of power, greater or lesser autonomy, more or less structured codes of behaviour, and more or less fluid roles for men and women.[^28] To these he later added measures of longer-term (self-denying) or shorter-term (self-gratifying) orientation. The seeming paradox lies in the fact that countries that score 'best' (as the prevailing climate of opinion would see it) in terms of these factors – that is to say societies with lower power inequalities, greater autonomy, less structured codes of behaviour, and 'low masculinity' – have higher rates of mental illness and suicide. That such an outcome should be labelled 'paradoxical' by professional psychologists is a measure of just how unquestioning has become our commitment to values which do in fact turn out to cause harm: if we were not so blindly committed to them, there would be no paradox, simply the observation that the values that

underpin the pursuit of hedonic happiness result in higher rates of mental illness and suicide. Satisfaction and happiness ratings in all modern societies that have been researched have declined as they have become more prosperous and more 'Westernised'.^[^29] (The decline has been particularly steep among women: over the 35 years between 1970 and 2005 women's happiness declined both absolutely and relative to men.^[^30]) The suicide prevalence in lower-income countries is lower than in higher-income groups, and in modernised societies higher than in traditional societies. In Britain, while suicide rates have always been and remain higher for men (roughly three times those for women), the rate of increase in suicide is steepest in young women between 10 and 24 years of age.^[^31] This is in line with findings in other Western countries.^[^32] Psychologist Jean Twenge studied rates of psychopathology in adolescents, relying on serial contemporaneous assessments using the same objective assessment tool and meeting stringent standards, over the period from 1938 to 2007. By these means she avoided the problems of retrospective accounts, of changing diagnostic fashions and of new patterns in willingness to seek help. She found that there were between five and eight times as many students that met a common cut-off for psychopathology in the latest cohort compared with the earliest, and this may be an underestimate because many recent subjects were already stabilised on an antidepressant, a possibility that did not exist for the earliest cohorts.^[^33]

A major 2018 survey, which charts social isolation using a common measure known as the UCLA Loneliness Scale, shows, according to Arthur Brooks, that loneliness is worse in each successive generation.

In the 'siloes', or isolated, worlds of cable television, ideological punditry, campus politics and social media, people find a sense of community in the polarized tribes forming on the left and the right in America. Essentially, people locate their sense of 'us' through the contempt peddled about 'them' on the other side of the political spectrum. There is profit to be made here. The 'outrage industrial complex' is what I call the industries that accumulate wealth and power by providing this simulacrum of community that people crave – but cannot seem to find in real life.^[^34]

Findings from the Cigna US Loneliness Index 2018 include: when asked how often they feel like no-one knows them well, more than half of the respondents surveyed said they feel that way always or sometimes; approaching half of respondents felt that their relationships were not meaningful; more than half of adults aged 18–22 identify with 10 of the 11 feelings associated with loneliness.^[^35]

There is clear contemporary research evidence that supports the positive correlation between suicide and individualism.^[^36] Durkheim had already observed in the late nineteenth century that the loss of the sense of belonging and having a secure role in a society – what he called anomie – and an individualistic casting off of well-defined societal values, norms, and goals – which he called égoïsme – are prominent concomitants of suicide.^[^37] Indeed, if you had set out to destroy the happiness and stability of a people, it would have been hard to improve on our current formula: remove yourself as far as possible from the natural world; repudiate the

continuity of your culture; believe you are wise enough to do whatever you happen to want and not only get away with it, but have a right to it – and a right to silence those who disagree; minimise the role played by a common body of belief; actively attack and dismantle every social structure as a potential source of oppression; and reject the idea of a transcendent set of values.

And there is a further point to make. Something noticeable has happened to our emotional range, which also illuminates how our values have been corrupted. It strikes me that, as a culture, we are losing the capacity for sorrow. This might sound like a good thing, but is far from being so. Indeed it may even be a sign that we are losing our humanity. Sorrow is a normal part of life, and nothing like anxiety and depression (in which, contrary to popular belief, a capacity for sorrow may be diminished). We have lost that sense of deep connexion and communion, eliciting feelings of longing, tenderness and compassion, and which is more prevalent than any other sense in the musical traditions of the whole world. Music, like great works of tragedy, and like the rites of a religion, acknowledges sorrow and redeems it by taking it up into something with a capacity to heal. In our world, in place of sorrow or sadness, we have anger, resentment and self-righteous indignation. Sorrow and sadness depend on connexion; anger, resentment and self-righteousness on alienation. Sorrow leads to insight; anger to blindness. As the reader will know a capacity for sorrow is closely connected to a capacity for empathy, and both are heavily dependent on the right hemisphere; whereas anger, like denial, is heavily dependent on the left hemisphere.^[^38] Our public expressions in art, in films, and in the stories and myths we espouse showcase conflict, self-assertion, violence, aggression, torture and horror – or alternatively a sentimental and unrelenting positivity – but little in the spectrum of sorrow, or tenderness, certainly when compared with other times and other cultures. This is part of our overvaluing of the rhetoric of power, which often seems to be the only value that gets discussed, whether it be in relation to political values, societal discourse or even the critique of works of art. With it goes a dereliction of the value of what is vulnerable. Given this rhetoric, it is hard for us to realise quite how much we close the door on when we are too brittle to allow ourselves to remain open to life as it is, not as we imagine it ought to be. In the face of all that we are destroying, we have lost, it seems, the capacity to mourn. Perhaps acknowledging the loss would be, for many of us, simply too painful.

THE INVERSION OF VALUES

I have suggested that values should be considered ontological primitives (ie, irreducible and foundational); that, of course, we may observe and esteem any one value or not, but that we do not manufacture them. Rather we recognise them, respond to them and help them grow – or not; and that in doing so, as in everything, the hemispheres see them differently. Max Scheler thought there was a hierarchy of values, with those of pleasure and utility – the values of utilitarianism and the left hemisphere – at the lowest level, and rising by stages to that of the holy or sacred, which he considered the highest: a value which I suggest is

incomprehensible to the left hemisphere. In between were, first, the *Lebenswerte* or values of 'life', such as courage, magnanimity, nobility, humility and loyalty;[^39] and then the *geistige Werte*, the values of mind or spirit, such as beauty, goodness and truth – which I have suggested are better understood by the right hemisphere. In the world we live in, the reductionist narrative is that holiness is a deceit employed by clergy to maintain power and privilege; that beauty is a tool of sexual selection; goodness and truth tools of social cohesion; the *Lebenswerte* merely opportunities for simple-minded individuals to indulge in self-sacrifice for the benefit of the group; and that all that really matters is pleasure and utility – the only values that do not require affective or moral engagement with the world. In other words, in a thoroughly cynical assessment of what it means to be human, we have inverted Scheler's hierarchy and exalted the individual ego. Instead of his *ens amans* we have *homo economicus*. This inversion is just as predicted from a culture marked by left hemisphere dominance. And it has rendered many virtues, including, but not confined to, beauty, goodness and truth, fugitive species.

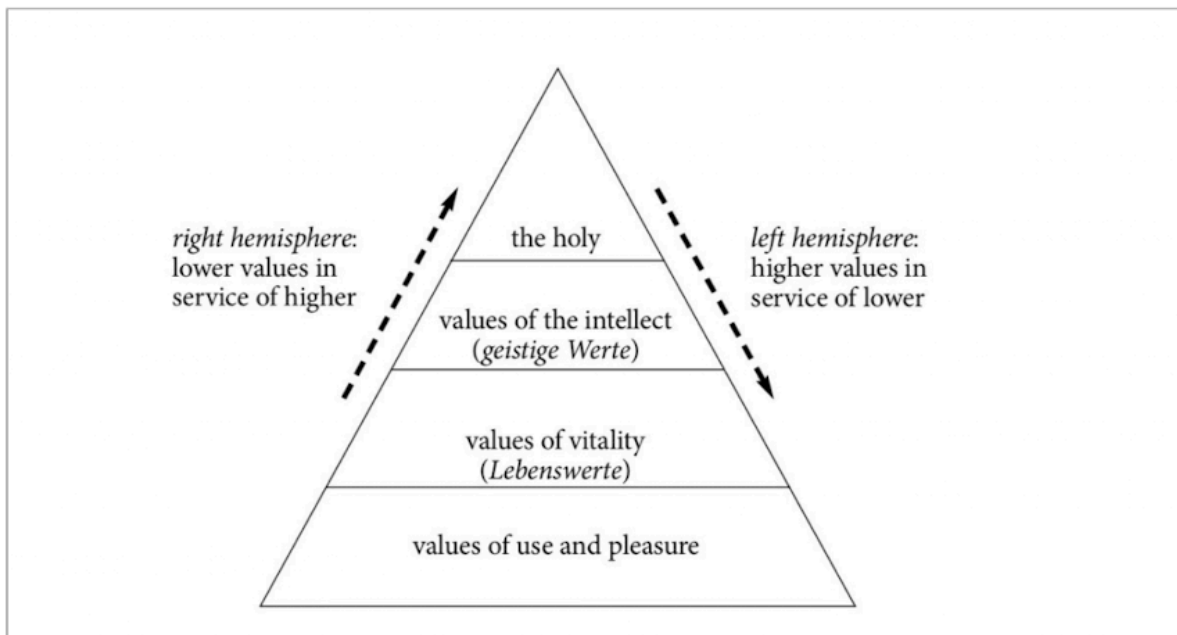


Fig. 62. Pyramid of values according to Scheler

The left hemisphere's *raison d'être* being power and control, it naturally puts values of utility and hedonism, those of the lowest rank in Scheler's pyramid, first. I may be wrong, but it is my distinct impression that there has been a decline in courage, loyalty and humility in our society – indeed in all behaviour that carries its costs upfront, rather than concealing its sting in the tail; speaking the truth takes courage, and it would seem that those in the institutions of government, science and the universities would rather conform than confront untruth. The powerhouses of intellect, the universities, have lost their nerve, and become passive, conformist and feeble – and excessively bureaucratic. Perhaps because of this I can't help

noticing that many of the most interesting ideas in science, in politics and in philosophy these days come from outside the institutions – something I say only with the greatest of regret, as someone who always saw himself as a proud beneficiary of their ancient traditions, and who wished to further those traditions. And along with the loss of courage to speak the truth, there has been an undeniable withdrawal from the beautiful and the sacred. All of this combines to reinforce a loss of sense of purpose and direction – or ‘the faintest idea of what we are doing’, in Walker Percy’s phrase. Hence the crisis of meaning that it is, by now, a commonplace that we face.

Considered just from the left hemisphere’s narrowly utilitarian point of view, its blind destruction of the three elements that are most important in securing our well-being – closeness to the natural world, social cohesion and embrace of the divine – is self-defeating. That these elements are so vital to well-being is not my opinion, but as near a fact as we can get. I deal with the evidence regarding the extraordinary range of beneficial effects on health, both physical and mental, and on resilience, happiness and fulfilment, associated with religious belief and observance in Appendix 8. I dealt with the similar evidence regarding social cohesion in *The Master and his Emissary*.^[^40] But there is equally impressive evidence attaching to the effects of our being close to Nature. A multitude of studies testify that spending time in Nature is conducive to improved physical and mental health on a wide range of indicators, to a sense of well-being and happiness, and to improved attention, cognition and social functioning; while deprivation can lead to the opposite, including anxiety, anger, and frustration, problems with attention and cognition, and the psychological and physical concomitants of stress.^[^41] The irony is that these three aspects of life, which can be fully appreciated only by transcending the narrowly utilitarian view, nonetheless ought, on purely rational grounds, to be embraced even by those whose values go no further than the wholly utilitarian. The non-utilitarian value of religious observance, social cohesion and closeness to Nature would have seemed a foregone conclusion in any other culture than our own: and now we know the utilitarian value is also overwhelming. Are we, suddenly, so ‘Bright’ after all? In summary, two things stand out. The first is that, although we are inextricably part of it, derive our whole existence from it, and are ourselves incomprehensible when sundered from it, we have abandoned Nature. Nature – not some abstract, eviscerated, bureaucratic entity known as ‘the environment’, which exists to be managed and exploited; not some technical set of mechanisms called an ecosystem; but Nature, whose meaning is that-which-is-about-to-be-born, and is feminine – and what’s more a goddess; Nature, that, like Kali, is wild, and gives life and destroys – or rather does not destroy, but transforms one being into another; ^[^42] Nature, that is our mother and our healer and our home, as well as our ultimate fate; Nature, that we are reviling and doing our best to devastate – is the great whole to which we belong. All the elements of the left hemisphere insurrection can, individually and together, be seen as an attack on Nature – and, with it, on the body; and hence on life itself. ‘Let us allow Nature to play her part’, wrote Montaigne, sceptic that he was: ‘she understands her business better than we do.’^[^43] Nowadays we are sceptical about Nature, because too often she refuses to behave according to our new rules. But scepticism of one position merely leads to certainty about another unless scepticism is equally applied to

its opposite; total scepticism of both leaves us impotent; a vestige of scepticism about scepticism re-engages us with a possible balanced solution.

The other thing that stands out is that we have abandoned even the pretence of seeking wisdom, instead intent on seeking power. Wisdom and humour are both expressions arising from the shared suffering involved in acquiring one of the greatest flowers of life, a sense of proportion. They are both important elements in turning us away from aggression and towards healing. But, for us now, humour is dying along with wisdom: the left hemisphere Puritans are seeing to that. Puritanism always was the enemy of both; and it has historically often been associated with aggression, destruction and a ferocious need to control – with power, in other words, above all else.

A member of the Swiss Parliament, Lukas Fierz, recalls as a boy meeting his celebrated neighbour, Carl Gustav Jung. In the course of conversation, Jung told us about his encounter with a Pueblo chief whose name was 'Mountain Lake'. This chief told him, that the white man was doomed. When asked why, the chief took both hands before his eyes and – Jung imitating the gesture – moved the outstretched index fingers convergingly towards one point before him, saying 'because the white man looks at only one point, excluding all other aspects'. Many years later, Dr Fierz, who is a physician and a founding member of the Green Party in Switzerland, recalls that a significant adversary of that movement was a successful industrialist and self-made billionaire:

I asked him what in his view was the reason for his incredible entrepreneurial and political success. He took both hands before his eyes and moved the outstretched index fingers convergingly towards one point before him, saying 'because I am able to concentrate on only one point, excluding all other aspects'. I remember that I had to swallow hard two or three times, so as not to say anything ...[^44]

The secret of success – of a kind; and the formula for ruin.

SO WHAT SHOULD WE DO?

I am convinced that it will do little good to tackle these problems piecemeal, while essentially retaining the mindset that caused them to arise in the first place. Of course at some stage the piecemeal method is necessary, even vital – the left hemisphere, in other words, acting properly as the useful servant, not the master. But such efforts are of no avail unless they form part of a greater project that involves radically revising our whole concept of the reality of which we are a part, and of who we are within it. Only then do we stand a chance of being possessed of a different set of values and of changing our behaviour accordingly. Without deep-rootedness and appropriate soil a tree will not stand. So, if we want to 'tackle climate change' we most certainly do have to take whatever steps are necessary to stop destroying the rain forests. But if we go on thinking of the extraordinary richness and beauty of abundant life in them merely in terms of what it can do for us, what it is 'worth' to us in terms of utility, which ultimately translates as economic value, we might as well forget trying to save

ourselves, and allow ourselves to sink.

As long ago as 1805 Schelling already saw the root of our malaise. There is no higher realisation in all of science, he believed (and he was well versed in the physics and chemistry of his time) and none higher in art, philosophy, or religion, than that of the sacredness of what, for want of language, he refers to as the 'All'; and that in those ages where we are mindful of this unity, a culture enjoys vigour, and vitality, and the fruits of the collaboration of the arts and sciences. But whenever the light of that revelation faded, and men came to see things not in relation to the All, but as distinct from one another – not in their unity, but in their disjunction – and in the same spirit came to conceive themselves as in isolation and estrangement from the All; then one sees science, lost in the desert expanses, struggling to take meagre steps in the furtherance of knowledge, grain of sand by grain of sand, so as to put the universe together. And with it one sees the beauty of life vanish; and the spread of a savage war of opinion over the most essential and important things, while everything falls apart in a mass of details.[⁴⁵]

Like Schelling, I believe that without an overarching understanding of the 'All' of which we are a part, however tentative and incomplete it must necessarily be, we are bound to go on acting in such a way that we lose everything we value – or all that, when in our right minds, we value. The left hemisphere has dismantled the universe and is unable to put it back together again. Without a radically different understanding we just can't carry on. That is why I have written this book.

Behind my attempt to offer a truer account of the reality in which we belong, there lie three fundamental questions. The first of these is: 'In our explorations of reality, how can we know what to trust – that is to say, to believe to be true of it – at least in the sense of truer than any of the alternatives?' Addressing that was the burden, in different respects, of Parts I and II of the book, and my answer was given at length in those pages. The second was this: 'What account of reality then emerges?' That was the burden of Part III. There I attempted to provide an account of what Schelling calls the 'All' that is richer and truer than the narrowly left hemisphere account which has been our lodestar for the last three hundred years or more, and which has brought us to this pass. It is in no sense a new account. Readers of the book will be well aware of the debt it owes to the wisdom of ancient myths and to the insights of philosophers over the centuries, many of whom have occupied a dissident place on the fringes of the dominant culture. What I hope I have done, however, is to bring fresh support to their insights from what the hemisphere hypothesis tells us – and, incidentally, from what recent, exciting, developments in the philosophy of both biology and physics are confirming. The hemisphere hypothesis demonstrates very clearly, I believe, that the prevailing account of the 'All' is the product of an unbalanced, untempered and characteristically domineering, go-it-alone left hemisphere view of the world, one that is false, impoverished and dangerous; and that a form of attention to the world that allows into the picture what the right hemisphere discerns produces a truer, richer account of the 'All', without which we shall perish.

The world, I suggest, is far different from the way it has been generally understood – with notable, mainly disregarded, exceptions – over Western history, certainly recent history. It is a world in which relationships are ontologically primary, foundational; and ‘things’ a secondary, emergent property of relationships. It is one where matter is an aspect of consciousness, not consciousness an emanation from matter. It is one in which there is a natural process of individuation, but one the aim of which, far from disrupting wholeness, is to enrich it. It is one where opposites are not as far as possible removed from one another but tend to coincide. Change and motion are the universal norm, without disrupting stability and duration. It is one where nothing is wholly determined, though there are constraints, and nothing is wholly random, though chance plays an important creative role. Indeed the whole cosmos is creative; it drives towards the realisation of an infinite potential. It is one to which we are profoundly connected – out of which we arise and to which we again revert; Nature being our specific home in that cosmos from which we come and to which in time we return. It is one that absolutely cannot be properly understood or appreciated without imagination and intuition, as well as reason and science: each plays a vitally important role. It is neither purposeless nor unintelligent, but simply beyond our full comprehension, though we are given enough insight to kindle wonder and awe, and the impetus to try to understand what little we can. It is an expression of energy and form, form within energy and energy within form, each both ‘challenging’ and ‘liberating’ the other to further creative realisation. It’s more a dance than an equation. And at the core is something we call the divine, which is itself forever coming into being along with the world that it forms, and by which, in turn, it too is formed.

And now: the third question, which follows from this, since we are part of the All: ‘We, then – who are we?’ On what grounds I base my answer to this last question, only the reader of this book will understand; but what I say is this. Ultimately of course we cannot really know fully who we are. But we can know what we are not. We are definitely not the lonely, isolated, predatory egos we have been taught to think of ourselves as being; hurled into an alien universe, mere accidents of cosmic history, whose lives, like the cosmos itself, are pitifully devoid of meaning, purpose and value. We are not the playthings of necessity. Nor in our dealings with Nature are we merely detached observers, manipulative, tinpot gods – in our dealings with one another forever doomed to fight with and destroy one another. Power and pleasure are not our only values, nor by any means our greatest values, nor do they on their own satisfy us, add beauty and goodness to existence, or help save us from ourselves. The boxes into which we force reality are a mental expedient, since no two things and no two people are ever really the same in any quality whatsoever, except the fact of their existence. This is central, because all is, once it is properly seen, unique; and it is the business of living to unfold that unending potential for uniqueness. At the same time nothing and no-one is ever wholly disconnected from anything else: the uniqueness is not in any way opposed to that connectedness, but vitally dependent on it, and in turn constitutive of it. We are temporarily material entities, capable, we do not know how or why, not just of awe before creation, but of playing a part in creation itself; beings that emerge out of the original consciousness, eddies in a seamless flow that embraces everything that is and was and will be; for a while distinct, but never wholly separate from the flow, since we are for a while that flow, wherever it finds

itself. We are embedded in the cosmos that gives rise to us: the least that can logically be said is that there is something about this cosmos that makes it such that we and all our capabilities, all our achievements and creations, for good or ill, can arise. They simply cannot come from anywhere other than the cosmos in which we belong. What is wonderful about us is not our pitiful lust for power, our self-absorption and our armour-plated invulnerability, but precisely our capacity to be vulnerable, to wonder, and to love: which alone makes what we most value possible.

This is all very well, someone might say, but it is a myth. That is of course true, but it doesn't deliver the hoped-for, knock-out blow. Just as there is no option to think without metaphor, there is no such thing as not having a myth: those who think they don't have a myth have merely bought into the prevailing myth of the time – in our case, the myth of the machine – so thoroughly that they are not even aware of it. Our only option is to espouse a worse or, one hopes, a better myth. As the reader will know, I have argued that myths, like metaphors, are by no means lies that are invented, but aspects of truth that are discovered, and form an inevitable, indeed crucial, part of the search for that truth. Myths oversee – or underwrite – what we are capable of seeing. The nature of the attention that we bring to bear on the world, and the values which we bring to the encounter, change what we find; and in some absolutely non-trivial sense, change what it is. At the same time, the encounter, as is always the way with encounters, changes who we are. Thus in addressing the question 'who are we?', the attention we pay and the values we hold both contribute to the answer which we receive.

The aim of this book has been to address the issue of values by, first, attempting to provide a truer account of the reality we inhabit and, then, of our identity within it. The answers, such as they are, that have emerged cannot be stated simply – a fact which explains what the reader may feel has been the inordinate length of the book. But the experience of readers of *The Master and his Emissary*, as they have reported and continue to report it to me, encourages me to believe that changing the whole way in which we see our lives, our experience, our world, can be achieved by such means. The account we give of ourselves helps determine our values, and hence our behaviour: and, since how we behave is central to whether we could ever save ourselves and our world from the current tragic state of affairs, all this matters profoundly. We need the best myth we can have. I offer a myth that I believe, if lived, will be found truer than the reductionist one peddled in the market place. One that promotes much needed healing, not further destruction. That is all. But on that 'all' everything depends. Remember Thoreau's words: it's not what you look at that matters, it's what you see. We need to bring ourselves to see a new Gestalt, one in which what seem like fragments of knowledge form part of a coherent whole. This book has covered a lot of ground; that was inevitable if I was to show that there are deep accords between patterns of phenomena arising in what are conventionally thought of as widely disparate areas of knowledge – neurology, philosophy, physics: a consilience (literally, 'a jumping together'), to use a fashionable word, that is together more revealing than its constituents could ever be apart. In reality they are never wholly separable. But I want to emphasise again: it is not just a matter of putting together ever more facts, but of developing an understanding. Neurology matters. It is not just a technical

exercise in electronics, whereby we discover more data about the 'circuitry'. It means absolutely nothing, unless it helps us better understand human minds and lives: who we are. Philosophy matters. It is not just a procedural business of logic-chopping and point-scoring. It means absolutely nothing, unless it helps us to a wiser view of human experience and the nature of human being. Physics matters. It is not just a tool for manipulating the world, but for understanding it. All three help answer the questions of what the world is and who we are, on which all else depends.

It will not surprise the reader that I have spent much time in the company of Roger Sperry, though I was never lucky enough to meet him. Like me he started out in the humanities, and of course he went on to be the person who most deeply investigated the significance of the bipartite human brain. Sperry was not merely a neuroscientist but a philosopher of considerable discernment, many of whose insights came from the research into hemisphere difference which won him the Nobel Prize. Reflecting on the ills of Western society nearly half a century ago, he wrote that 'what it comes down to is that modern society discriminates against the right hemisphere.'⁴⁶ He later amplified this observation:

By evolutionary time standards, the fate of life on our planet has suddenly, and quite abruptly, come to rest on an entirely new form of security and control, based on the machinery of the human brain. The older, noncognitive controls of nature that have regulated events in our biosphere for hundreds of millions of years, the forces of nature that lifted life from the amoeboid to the human level and created man, are no longer in command. Modern man has intervened and now superimposes on nature his own cognitive brand of global domination... Any attempt to attack directly the overt symptoms of our global condition – pollution, poverty, aggression, overpopulation, and so on – can hardly succeed until the requisite changes are first achieved in the underlying human values involved. Once the subjective value factor has been adjusted, corrections will follow readily in the more concrete features of the system ... Among the vast complex of forces that influence and control the brain and behaviour of man, the factor of human values stands out as a universal determinant of all human decisions and actions ...⁴⁷

This book is my best attempt to address Sperry's concern and to suggest how 'the factor of human values' he sees as all-determining might be shifted from its current, catastrophic, condition.

Let me be clear: replacing the right hemisphere in its proper position, one in which the left hemisphere works with it, but serves it, rather than aims to control it, is not to wish for some dream of softness, lack of rigour and ease. Quite the opposite. This is not an easy path. It makes demands on us, far more than the selfish, complacent vision of the left hemisphere has ever done: which just adds to the reasons we don't want to change. As the reader has seen, the right hemisphere has more of a grasp of moral values, is apt to take responsibility rather than blame others, is more apt to inhibit our first impulse to what is simple and easy, is more intelligent, and complicates our simple mechanistic vision by its insight. And for the umpteenth time, as the reader of this book knows, we do not achieve any of this by turning our backs on reason and on science. As I have explained, the right hemisphere makes the

most valuable contribution to both. If anything reason and science are worryingly diminished in our world: reason, by its narrowness, become unreasonable; science, by its narrowness, unscientific. Both have become tarnished by dogma. We should expect not less, but more and better of both; it is dogma we must avoid at all costs. Dogma is the besetting sin of the age; and if one wanted one it would be hard to find a better expression of the left hemisphere's take on the world than dogma.

Towards the end of his life Einstein was asked if he had any regrets. Reportedly he replied: 'I wish I had read more of the mystics earlier in my life.'^[48] I have been forcibly struck by the remarkable similarities in the wisdom enshrined in writings coming out of a breadth of traditions – Hindu, Taoist, Buddhist, Christian, Hebrew, Islamic, those of the ancient cultures of North America, or those of ancient Greece – that I have encountered; and I would be surprised, on that basis, if there were not a great number more, not just texts but whole traditions, of which I remain ignorant, that could be added to such a body of wisdom. Scheler wrote that 'every finite spirit believes either in a God or in an idol.'^[49] Having abandoned God, our idol is – ourselves, as 'God': the gaining of human power over every manifestation of Nature, so as to subdue it in the furtherance of a plan that came to us, viewed from a historical perspective, barely minutes ago, and which we have therefore had no opportunity properly to evaluate, and whose outcome is fully unknown, although we can already see the most ominous signs that mean we can't possibly go on living the way we do now. 'Nothing is more useful than power, nothing more frightful', wrote Heschel. 'We have often suffered from degradation by poverty, now we are threatened with degradation through power.'^[50] Despite being deeply suspicious of a great deal of 'God talk' myself, and while fully acknowledging the problematic nature of the very word God, I feel our repudiation of God is not a wise move. It is easy to misunderstand what cultures wiser than ours were trying to express by speaking of God; still easier to reject the idea of God entirely. But easy is not enough. It is our duty to do the more difficult thing: to find out the core of wisdom in this ill-understood, though universal, insight, for that there is such an inestimably valuable core seems to me more credible than anything else I know.

I have said what I can. If you wish more, I can do no better than repeat the words of the seventeenth-century priest and physician, Angelus Silesius:
Friend, that is surely enough. And should you want to read more,
Then go and become yourself the words, and yourself the Being.^[51]

[^1]: Walker Percy

[^2]: I Ching

[^3]: Walter Benjamin

[^4]: (They also turn out from contemporary research, unsurprisingly, to be the three elements that most determine one's happiness and fulfilment as a human being.)

[^5]: The Secret of the Golden Flower

[^6]: Thomas Cleary comments: 'Zen Buddhism traditionally describes the mechanism of delusion as mistaking the servant for the master. In the metaphor of this passage, the general is supposed to be a servant but instead usurps authority.'

[^7]: When 'the sword is turned around ... the original mind retrieves command over the delinquent conscious mind'.

[^8]: In this way the intellect [LH] functions efficiently in the world without that conscious activity inhibiting access to deeper spontaneous knowledge through the direct intuition of a more subtle faculty [RH].

[^9]: To quote Heidegger once more, 'The evil and thus keenest danger is thinking itself. It must think against itself, which it can only seldom do.'

[^10]: no vestige of subtlety in our thinking,

[^11]: There is another major feature of thought: thought doesn't know it is doing something and then it struggles against what it is doing. It doesn't want to know that it is doing it. And it struggles against the results, trying to avoid those unpleasant results while keeping on with that way of thinking. That is what I call sustained incoherence.

[^12]: 'If there is sustained incoherence, it just keeps on going in spite of the fact that there is evidence which would show that it's incoherent. Now, we could say that an intelligent response on seeing incoherence would be to stop it, to suspend it and begin to look out for the reason for the incoherence and then to change it. But I say there is a defensive incoherence'.

[^13]: Once they are committed to their theory of how things work, drawing attention to its glaringly obvious failure in the real world leads not to a flicker of doubt, but to a rise in confidence and redoubled efforts along the same line.

[^14]: The person who ... keeps on striving when the maximum of influence has already been achieved, knowing only how to press forward and not how to retreat, isolates himself from the human sphere and loses his success. For what is complete cannot endure, and what is pushed to the limit ends in misfortune. Thus the last line says, 'Arrogant dragon will have cause to repent'.

[^15]: 'No self is of itself alone', wrote Schrödinger: 'The "I" is chained to ancestry by many factors ... This is not mere allegory, but an eternal memory.'

[^16]: 'The individual actually grows', wrote the social philosopher Norbert Elias, 'from a network of people existing before him into a network that he helps to form: the individual person is not a beginning and his relations to other people have no beginnings.' And he compares it to a conversation where 'the questions of one evoke the answers of the other and vice versa', something that 'can be understood – like the figure of a thread in a net – only from the totality of the network'.

[^17]: For this reason, as Viktor Frankl observed, 'individuality can only be valuable when it is

not individuality for its own sake, but individuality for the human community.'

[^18]: ... the reason is, of course, the want of pre-existent balance, the organism's way of digesting all it absorbs, using and rejecting according to its form. We thus find ourselves in a vicious circle: because we lack the organic sense to begin with, we misuse or deform the trends in our world that should move us toward it.

[^19]: The insight is present in Rumi;

[^20]: 'Language immediately makes a claim for itself to be a prince among the mental processes, and to be the exclusive medium of mental function, denying often by its existence the presence of other modes of thought.'

[^21]: One of the obvious things wrong with thought is fragmentation. Thought is breaking things up into bits which should not be broken up ... and at the same time we are trying to establish unity where there isn't any [through categorisation] ... Thus we have false division and false unification. Thought is always doing a great deal, but it tends to say that it hasn't done anything, that it is just telling you the way things are ... that 'you' are inside there, deciding what to do with the information. But I want to say that you don't decide what to do with the information. The information takes over. It runs you. Thought runs you. Thought, however, gives the false information that you are running it, that you are the one who controls thought, whereas actually thought is the one which controls each one of us. Until thought is understood – better yet, more than understood, perceived – it will actually control us; but it will create the impression that it is our servant, that it is just doing what we want it to do.

[^22]: But his astonishingly clear insight is that, as I too believe, we are in the grip of something bigger than us that tells us it has our interests at heart in order the better to control us. And it has been devastatingly successful.

[^23]: When the machine presumes to inhabit our minds, / rather than be at our command, / it threatens everything we have achieved. / That the lovelier hesitancy of the master's hand / may be no longer manifest, it cuts the stone / for its more resolute work to an unyielding line. / It tarries nowhere, so that we might escape from it, / just for once – and leave it be, / oiling away in some quiet factory. / It is life – it thinks it knows best, / as it orders and makes and destroys / with the same determination.

[^24]: D.H. Lawrence referred to 'the true unconscious, where our life bubbles up in us, prior to any mentality';

[^25]: and elsewhere, in speaking of his embodied existence, whether sick or well, 'I am alive, alive to the depths of my soul, and in touch somewhere with the vivid life of the cosmos'.

[^26]: Our time is cursed with the necessity for feeble men, masquerading as experts, to make enormously far-reaching decisions ... You can stop splitting the atom; you can stop visiting the moon; you can stop using aerosols; you may even decide not to kill entire populations by the use of a few bombs. But you cannot recall a new form of life ... The world is given to us on loan. We come and we go; and after a time we leave earth and air and water to others who come after us. My generation, or perhaps the one preceding mine, has been the first to engage, under the leadership of the exact sciences, in a destructive colonial warfare against nature. The future will curse us for it.

[^27]: By contrast with hedonic happiness, it protects against depression, and lowers all-cause mortality: it is also more dependent on the right hemisphere.

[^28]: Cultures can be characterised by four main measures, according to the most widely adopted criteria in cross-cultural psychology, those of Geert Hofstede: greater or lesser inequalities of power, greater or lesser autonomy, more or less structured codes of behaviour, and more or less fluid roles for men and women.

[^29]: Satisfaction and happiness ratings in all modern societies that have been researched have declined as they have become more prosperous and more 'Westernised'.

[^30]: (The decline has been particularly steep among women: over the 35 years between 1970 and 2005 women's happiness declined both absolutely and relative to men.)

[^31]: In Britain, while suicide rates have always been and remain higher for men (roughly three times those for women), the rate of increase in suicide is steepest in young women between 10 and 24 years of age.

[^32]: This is in line with findings in other Western countries.

[^33]: She found that there were between five and eight times as many students that met a common cut-off for psychopathology in the latest cohort compared with the earliest, and this may be an underestimate because many recent subjects were already stabilised on an antidepressant, a possibility that did not exist for the earliest cohorts.

[^34]: In the 'siloed', or isolated, worlds of cable television, ideological punditry, campus politics and social media, people find a sense of community in the polarized tribes forming on the left and the right in America. Essentially, people locate their sense of 'us' through the contempt peddled about 'them' on the other side of the political spectrum. There is profit to be made here. The 'outrage industrial complex' is what I call the industries that accumulate wealth and power by providing this simulacrum of community that people crave – but cannot seem to find in real life.

[^35]: Findings from the Cigna US Loneliness Index 2018 include: when asked how often they feel like no-one knows them well, more than half of the respondents surveyed said they feel that way always or sometimes; approaching half of respondents felt that their relationships were not meaningful; more than half of adults aged 18–22 identify with 10 of the 11 feelings associated with loneliness.

[^36]: There is clear contemporary research evidence that supports the positive correlation between suicide and individualism.

[^37]: Durkheim had already observed in the late nineteenth century that the loss of the sense of belonging and having a secure role in a society – what he called anomie – and an individualistic casting off of well-defined societal values, norms, and goals – which he called égoïsme – are prominent concomitants of suicide.

[^38]: As the reader will know a capacity for sorrow is closely connected to a capacity for empathy, and both are heavily dependent on the right hemisphere; whereas anger, like denial, is heavily dependent on the left hemisphere.

[^39]: In between were, first, the Lebenswerte or values of 'life', such as courage, magnanimity, nobility, humility and loyalty;

[^40]: I dealt with the similar evidence regarding social cohesion in The Master and his Emissary.

[^41]: A multitude of studies testify that spending time in Nature is conducive to improved physical and mental health on a wide range of indicators, to a sense of well-being and

happiness, and to improved attention, cognition and social functioning; while deprivation can lead to the opposite, including anxiety, anger, and frustration, problems with attention and cognition, and the psychological and physical concomitants of stress.

[^42]: Nature, that, like Kali, is wild, and gives life and destroys – or rather does not destroy, but transforms one being into another;

[^43]: 'Let us allow Nature to play her part', wrote Montaigne, sceptic that he was: 'she understands her business better than we do.'

[^44]: I asked him what in his view was the reason for his incredible entrepreneurial and political success. He took both hands before his eyes and moved the outstretched index fingers convergingly towards one point before him, saying 'because I am able to concentrate on only one point, excluding all other aspects'. I remember that I had to swallow hard two or three times, so as not to say anything ...

[^45]: And with it one sees the beauty of life vanish; and the spread of a savage war of opinion over the most essential and important things, while everything falls apart in a mass of details.

[^46]: Reflecting on the ills of Western society nearly half a century ago, he wrote that 'what it comes down to is that modern society discriminates against the right hemisphere.'

[^47]: By evolutionary time standards, the fate of life on our planet has suddenly, and quite abruptly, come to rest on an entirely new form of security and control, based on the machinery of the human brain. The older, noncognitive controls of nature that have regulated events in our biosphere for hundreds of millions of years, the forces of nature that lifted life from the amoeboid to the human level and created man, are no longer in command. Modern man has intervened and now superimposes on nature his own cognitive brand of global domination... Any attempt to attack directly the overt symptoms of our global condition – pollution, poverty, aggression, overpopulation, and so on – can hardly succeed until the requisite changes are first achieved in the underlying human values involved. Once the subjective value factor has been adjusted, corrections will follow readily in the more concrete features of the system ... Among the vast complex of forces that influence and control the brain and behaviour of man, the factor of human values stands out as a universal determinant of all human decisions and actions ...

[^48]: Reportedly he replied: 'I wish I had read more of the mystics earlier in my life.'

[^49]: Scheler wrote that 'every finite spirit believes either in a God or in an idol.'

[^50]: 'Nothing is more useful than power, nothing more frightful', wrote Heschel. 'We have often suffered from degradation by poverty, now we are threatened with degradation through power.'

[^51]: Friend, that is surely enough. And should you want to read more, / Then go and become yourself the words, and yourself the Being.